The Adventures of Toto

The big idea

Ruskin Bond humorously narrates the mischief of **Toto**, a pet **monkey** his grandfather bought. Toto destroys things, scares the family and creates chaos until Grandfather finally decides he cannot keep him. The story shows the **joys and troubles of keeping wild animals as pets**.

Summary

1. **Grandfather** bought Toto from a **tonga-driver** for **five rupees**. The tonga-driver kept the little red monkey tied to a feeding trough.
2. Toto had bright, mischievous eyes, pearly white teeth and a long tail that served as a third hand. Grandfather hid him in a **cupboard** opening into the narrator's bedroom, tied to a peg. Toto tore the **wallpaper** and the narrator's school **blazer**.
3. Next he was put in a **big cage** in the servants' quarters with Grandfather's other pets: a tortoise, rabbits, a tame squirrel and a goat. Toto kept them awake at night.
4. When Grandfather went to **Saharanpur** to collect his pension, he took Toto in a **bag**. At the station the **ticket collector** insisted the monkey was a "dog" and charged **three rupees** as its fare. Grandfather took out Toto in protest, but had to pay.
5. At home Toto was kept in the **stable** with **Nana, the donkey**, whose ear Toto pulled and bit.
6. Toto loved warm water. One day he climbed into a **large kettle** on the fire and nearly **boiled himself** before Grandmother pulled him out.

7. He ate the **pulao** prepared for guests, and when Grandmother shrieked, he threw a plate at her and escaped up a jackfruit tree with the dish.
8. Toto also broke dishes and tore clothes. Finally Grandfather, admitting the family was too poor to keep him, **sold Toto back** to the tonga-driver for **three rupees**.

Characters

- **Toto**: intelligent, mischievous, destructive, clever and lovable.
- **Grandfather**: animal lover, patient and good-humoured, keeps a private zoo.
- **Grandmother**: tolerant but often troubled by Toto.

Themes

- **Humour** of a pet's antics.
- Wild animals need their natural freedom; keeping them is difficult.
- Love for animals.

MONEY TRAIL

Bought for **Rs 5**, train fare for "dog" **Rs 3**, sold back for **Rs 3**.

TOTO WAS NOT SOLD FOR A PROFIT

Grandfather sold Toto for less than he paid (Rs 3, not Rs 5). The family was glad just to be rid of the damage.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

How did Toto reach Saharanpur? What happened with the kettle? Why did Grandfather sell Toto? Describe Toto's appearance. Is it right to keep wild animals as pets?

Quick recap

- Bought for Rs 5; mischief in cupboard, cage, stable.
- Train trip: charged as a dog; kettle bath; pulao incident.
- Sold back for Rs 3.

Practice questions

1. From whom did Grandfather buy Toto?
   (a) A circus owner (b) A tonga-driver (c) A zoo keeper (d) A street performer
2. How much did Grandfather pay for Toto?
   (a) Three rupees (b) Ten rupees (c) Five rupees (d) Two rupees
3. What did the ticket collector classify Toto as?
   (a) A cat (b) A dog (c) Luggage (d) A parrot
4. Which animal shared the stable with Toto?
   (a) A goat (b) A horse (c) A cow (d) Nana the donkey
5. How did Toto nearly boil himself?
   (a) He sat in a kettle of water heating on the fire (b) He fell into a pot of dal (c) He jumped into a hot bath (d) He drank boiling tea
6. Why did Grandfather finally sell Toto?
   (a) Toto fell ill (b) Grandmother left home (c) The tonga-driver demanded him back (d) The family could not afford his destructive mischief
7. Describe the kettle incident.

Answers: 1. b 2. c 3. b 4. d 5. a 6. d 7. see notes